

Jupiter's moons

Jupiter has 67 known moons (and probably many more that haven't yet been spotted). Most are tiny, and dark in colour. Scientists think many of them are asteroids that have been caught by Jupiter's immense gravity.



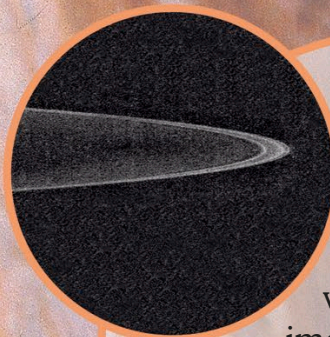
Ganymede (right), the solar system's largest moon, makes our moon (left) seem rather small.



Europa

The Galilean moons

Jupiter's largest moons are Io, Europa, Ganymede, and Callisto. One of these – Io – was shown by *Voyager 1* to have volcanoes that are so active that its surface is constantly disturbed.



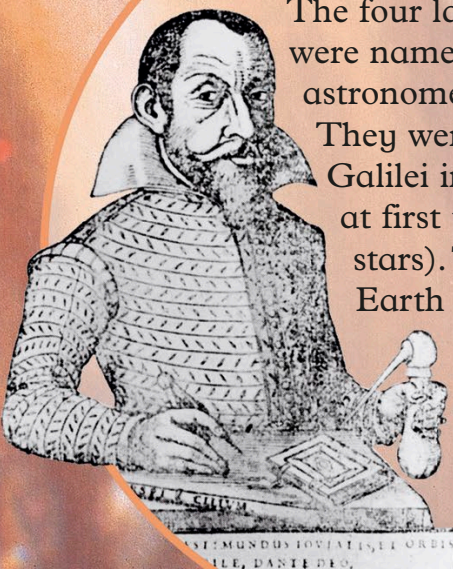
There are rings, too

Jupiter also has a ring system, which was first seen in images captured by the *Voyager 1* space probe in 1979. The rings were formed by dust kicked up when meteorites hit Jupiter's four inner moons.

Moon spotting

The four largest moons were named by a German astronomer, Simon Marius.

They were studied by Galileo Galilei in 1610 (who thought at first that they were small stars). They can be seen from Earth with good binoculars.



Simon Marius



Io

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